

# EAST ASIAN WEAPONS

**Staff weapons, the bow and the gun** – rather than the sword – were often the primary weapons of Japanese and Chinese military forces. Despite their technological advances, east Asian armies’ firepower was initially limited: although the Chinese had invented gunpowder, it was reintroduced in a more effective form in the Middle East and Europe in the 16th century. Around the same time, in 1543, the matchlock gun arrived in Japan, and was used in large numbers; however, during the peaceful Edo period (1603–1868), gun-making in Japan all but ceased.

▲ GUANDAO

|        |               |
|--------|---------------|
| Date   | 19th century  |
| Origin | China         |
| Weight | 5.2kg (11½lb) |
| Length | 2.52m (8¼ft)  |

Staff weapons of this type, resembling European glaives, had been in use for centuries in China. Made in the style of a 16th-century weapon, this example has a thin, flexible blade issuing from a cast-brass guard that resembles a dragon’s head.

Brass-bound shaft

Hand guard of brass

Long wooden shaft

Hook on rear edge of blade

► YARI

|        |                 |
|--------|-----------------|
| Date   | 16th century    |
| Origin | Japan           |
| Length | 1–6m (3¼–19½ft) |

The *yari* was a straight-headed spear. Its length ranged from 1m (3ft) to 6m (20ft). The longer versions were called *omi no yari*, while the shorter ones were known as *mochi* or *tae yari*. The longest versions were carried by foot troops, and the shorter versions by samurai.

Match-holder

Elaborate sight block holds blades of varying heights for different ranges

Lock and furniture made of brass to resist corrosion

Trigger

▲ KAKAE ZUTSU

|         |                   |
|---------|-------------------|
| Date    | 17th–19th century |
| Origin  | Japan             |
| Weight  | 6.7kg (14¾lb)     |
| Barrel  | 67.5cm (26½in)    |
| Calibre | 18.7mm            |

*Kakae zutsu* (hand cannon), some with bores of up to 2cm (¾in) in diameter, were used to batter down doors and to launch incendiary missiles. Their weight meant that they had to be shot from the waist, or from a support. The lock in this example has an internal spiral spring to operate the match-holder.

Serpentine match-holder is forward-facing

Owner’s heraldry

Bore standardized to simplify ammunition supply

Brass lock cover plate

▲ HI NAWA JU

|         |                   |
|---------|-------------------|
| Date    | 17th–19th century |
| Origin  | Japan             |
| Weight  | 1.29kg (2¾lb)     |
| Barrel  | 93.7cm (36¾in)    |
| Calibre | 15mm              |

The *hi nawa ju* (matchlock gun) was introduced to Japan by the Portuguese from their base at Goa, India, in 1543. Within 25 years, manufacturing centres were producing thousands of these guns for arming foot soldiers, and the matchlock had become a decisive weapon in battle. The decoration in black and gold lacquer was added later.

Decorative brass inlay

Leather-covered grip

Disc-shaped guard

Match-holder

Steeply bent butt

Long bar-trigger

▲ CHANGDAO

|        |              |
|--------|--------------|
| Date   | 16th century |
| Origin | China        |
| Weight | 2.72kg (6lb) |
| Length | 1.57m (5¼ft) |

Chinese long swords of this kind are similar to the Japanese swords known as *ōdachi*. However, unlike the *ōdachi*, the *changdao* has a long tang riveted through the brass pommel cap.

Stock made of red oak

Thumb lever for cocking hammer